

A DISCOURSE ON THE OGBIA PEOPLE AND THE RELEVANCE OF THEIR SOCIAL MASQUERADE CULTURE

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Abstract

Culture is a way of expressing a people's identity through beliefs, institutions, artefacts, and creative arts. Social masquerades among the Ogbia people of Bayelsa State are some of the key cultural performances that have helped in sustaining communal cohesion, artistic education, and heritage preservation. While these masquerades-Oki of Otuobhi, Akpembe of Ewoi, Odemimom of Otuoke, and Oburumadu of Emeyal II-are important, they have not received adequate scholarly attention, perhaps because scholarship has often been focused on ritualistic masquerades. This work therefore investigates the origin, development, and contemporary relevance of Ogbia social masquerades by looking into their functions in the context of cultural expression, community integration, and youth engagement. Historical, sociological, and emic approaches were employed in carrying out this research, including archival review, interviews with custodians, participant observation, and performance documentation. The study is anchored on the Functionalist Theory, especially the Durkheimian perspective. Findings show that Ogbia social masquerades retain cultural identity despite the removal of ritualistic features. Neighboring culture adaptation and de-ritualization have made them more accessible. Based on the results obtained, this study recommends that masquerade performances should be recorded, and promoted by various programs to ensure their sustainability and relevance. In conclusion, the Ogbia social masquerades remain dynamic cultural resources that enhance cohesion, provide talent development, and ensure that cultural heritage stays relevant in the modern world. The secular and uniting nature of the masquerades ensures that cultural caliber stays relevant in a world of globalization and modernization.

Introduction

The culture of a people is expressed in their way of life, their institutions, ideologies, artifacts, creative arts, and dress code. These patterns distinguish them from their neighbors. Zulu Sofola conceptualizes culture as the “learned patterns of behavior, ideas, beliefs and artifacts, shared by a people and society, transmitted by them from one generation to the other” (qtd. in Ejeke 64). These transmitted patterns form the worldview, belief system, and interactions with the supernatural, thereby underscoring culture as a dynamic system of continuity and adaptation.

In Nigeria, according to Sam Ukala, masquerades often represent ancestors or supernatural beings, and their functions vary from ritualistic to social contexts (162). Ritualistic

masquerades, Ogonna Onuora states, are considered sacred and were traditionally restricted to initiates, with women, children, and non-initiates excluded (132). The Ebu masquerade of the Ebu people of Oshimili in Delta State exemplifies this reverence, forbidding photography during performances to avoid incurring the spirit's anger (Asenime 191). However, with the advent of modernity and diminishing ritualistic sensibilities, the sacredness of masquerades has declined. Some, like the Ebu masquerade, are now publicly documented, and their authority increasingly depends on the support of devotees (Ogunba 7; Enekwe 57). This transformation reflects a broader process of cultural adaptation and has led to the rise of social masquerades, which, while divested of sacredness and metaphysical essence, remain significant as forms of entertainment and cultural expression. Social masquerades occur during carnivals, marriages, funerals, and festive seasons, and are inclusive of all community members.

Among the Ogbia, the emphasis is on social masquerades. For instance, the Egugum masquerade of Ologoghe is described as a social masquerade with the main objectives of recreation, cultural propagation, preservation, as well as traditional artistic education (Amange 4). These masquerades do not segregate on the basis of attendance; men, women, and children participate, and performances are carried out in open squares during the day without ritualistic or spiritual inclination (Amange 7). This inclusive and performative orientation foregrounds their role as communal and cultural practices rather than sacred institutions.

The Ogbia social masquerades, which include Oki of Otuobhi, Akpembe of Ewoi, Odemimom of Otuoke, and Oburumadu of Emeyal, are completely stripped of magical or ritualistic functions. They are built on the day of display and destroyed thereafter to prevent deification, a process which Ademola Dasylva has described as “de-ritualization.” This process is not merely a loss of sacred essence but reflects a transformation in performance practice and cultural meaning. They serve as entertainment, uphold culture, and provide traditional artistic training, thereby functioning as mechanisms of cultural continuity, social cohesion, and identity formation within a changing socio-cultural environment. This study, therefore, discourses the Ogbia social masquerades in the modern world in order to foreground and interrogate their continued relevance.

While masquerade culture in Africa has been one of the most widely studied subjects, the literature tends mostly to focus on ritualistic and sacred masquerades, excluding those that are purely social or secular. The Ogbia people have such social masquerades as Oki of Otuobhi, Akpembe of Ewoi, Odemimom of Otuoke, and Oburumadu of Emeyal, which perform vital functions in the areas of entertainment, education, and communal bonding, but which receive scant scholarly attention. Most studies either generalize African masquerades or impose ritualistic interpretations on them, leaving the specific characteristics, origins, and social relevance of Ogbia social masquerades underexplored. Little, therefore, is known in terms of documentation and critical analysis of how these performances contribute to the preservation and promotion of culture, social unity, and artistic education within Ogbia society. This study addresses this gap by moving beyond documentation to an analytical engagement with the meanings and functions of these performances.

This gap is of paramount importance in the wake of modernity and globalization, which threaten indigenous cultural practices through homogenization, urban migration, and evolving social values. Within this context, Ogbia social masquerades should not be viewed as

diminished forms of ritual practice but as adaptive cultural expressions negotiating continuity and change. If this aspect remains underexplored in scholarship, these masquerades risk marginalization within the discourse of African performance studies. Thus, the objective of this study is to present an in-depth discourse on the Ogbia people and their social masquerade culture, with a view to demonstrating their enduring relevance as dynamic cultural resources.

Literature Review

Conceptualisation of Masquerade

Masquerade as a phenomenon in African cultures has been seen as a well-rounded performance in which several facets, including spirituality, performance, social control, and art, come together as a complete package. In African performance studies, masquerade has been understood as a platform through which the community communicates with the spirit world by virtue of performance. John Mbiti, in African religious thought, interprets masquerade as a performative medium that enables the community's communication with the spiritual world. In this regard, the masquerade performance assumes the identity of a "living drama," symbolizing ancestral spirits, gods, or supernatural beings (4). This notion of "living drama" reflects the African cosmological worldview in which existence is conceived as a continuum where the physical and spiritual realms co-exist and interact.

Masquerade is also identified as a theatrical medium wherein the performer assumes a symbolic role or identity. According to Yemi Ogunbiyi, masquerade is "a form of ritual theatre wherein the performer is transformed into a supernatural being through the use of mask and costume" (41). This transformation is not only physical but also symbolic and, in some contexts, spiritual, as the masquerade is believed to embody or represent the spirit it portrays. Such embodiment aligns with performance theory notions of identity transformation and role assumption within ritual and theatrical spaces.

In contemporary understandings, masquerade has been defined as either ritualistic or entertainment-oriented. Meki Nzewi demonstrates that masquerades in Africa are intrinsically linked to musical and dramatic expressions, functioning as "total performances" that reflect social structures, values, and collective consciousness (35). This perspective underscores masquerade as a dynamic cultural phenomenon capable of adaptation, thereby reinforcing its continued relevance within changing socio-cultural contexts.

Types of Masquerades

In the quest for a formidable masquerade theatre aesthetics, scholars have postulated different types of masquerades ranging from the spiritual to the secular, each with distinct functions. Some masquerades serve ritual or religious purposes, while others are social or secular. Those that have lost their spiritual propensities are mainly for entertainment. Sam Ukala, in his study of masquerade aesthetics, identifies two main types: ritualistic and social masquerades. The ritualistic type performs in contexts such as appeasement of spiritual forces, burial rites, invocation of deities, and communal purification. The social masquerade, on the other hand, performs mainly during the day, along streets, in front of houses, or in village squares. It is accessible to all members of the community and is intended to entertain and, in some cases, instruct spectators through representational performance (162–164). This distinction provides a functional framework for understanding masquerade practices within

African societies.

Studying the Oluyare masquerade of Ile-Ife, Areo observes that:

Masquerade in the society, apart from those staged for ritual purposes, have other purposes. Some are to entertain, and others, like the Oluyare, are to re-enact or narrate the life of a hero or heroine, thus encouraging and rewarding patriotism, selflessness, and courage in the society (67).

This perspective highlights the role of masquerade in identity formation and moral instruction within the community. These dual manifestations of masquerade are also captured by Anderson et al., who, using Izon cosmology as a case study, identify religious and secular masquerades. The religious masquerades incarnate as spirits and may function in social regulation, conflict resolution, and spiritual enforcement, while the secular masquerades imitate spiritual forms primarily for dramatic and aesthetic purposes (133). This distinction reflects broader processes of cultural differentiation and adaptation.

In agreement with Anderson, Asigbo lends credence to the classification of religious and social masquerades, noting that the former perform roles such as healing, cleansing, and enforcement of law and order, while the latter are primarily for entertainment (3). Asigbo further observes that social masquerades are commonly performed during festive occasions by age grades and cultural groups, with colourful costumes and performative elements designed to enhance audience engagement. This reinforces the understanding of masquerade as performance practice embedded within social life.

Further contributing to this classification, Ekweariri confirms that some masquerades are essentially entertainment personified, particularly within Igbo seasonal festivals where age-grade performances dominate public spaces such as village squares, streets, and marketplaces (82). Such performances illustrate the role of masquerade in public cultural expression and communal interaction.

These categories are also reflected in the classification by Okeke as day and night masquerades. The day masquerade performs in public spaces during the day and is accessible to all, aligning with the social masquerade category. It is devoid of ritualistic features, not stored in shrines, and not venerated. Social masquerades may emerge as adaptations or de-ritualized forms of ritual masquerades, reflecting processes of cultural transformation, or as creative expressions of traditional artistic ingenuity.

On the other hand, the night masquerade is associated with ritual functions, including the regulation of social order and the symbolic banishment of harmful forces within the community (Okeke 118). These masquerades are often restricted in audience and participation, with their masks preserved in shrines or sacred groves, reinforcing their ritual significance. However, ritualistic masquerades are not exclusively nocturnal, as some appear during the day depending on their function. For instance, the Amaseikumor masquerade of Gbaramatu Kingdom in Delta State appears in daylight, performing cleansing and blessing functions within the community. This illustrates the fluidity of masquerade practices and cautions against rigid categorization, thereby reinforcing the need for contextual analysis.

Theoretical Framework

This research employs Functionalist Theory, specifically the Durkheimian perspective, as its theoretical framework. Functionalist views regard social phenomena as integral components of a system in which each element contributes to the maintenance of social continuity and stability. Émile Durkheim conceptualizes social customs and cultural practices as mechanisms through which societies sustain cohesion and collective consciousness. In this regard, cultural forms are not incidental but serve identifiable functions that reinforce social order and shared values.

Within the context of the Ogbia community, the use of masquerades such as Oki of Otuobhi, Akpembe of Ewoi, Odemimom of Otuoke, and Oburumadu of Emeyal serves as an important cultural mechanism for fostering social cohesion. Although these masquerades appear secular and de-ritualized, they continue to perform essential social functions. They provide avenues for cultural education and transmission, particularly among the youth, through participation in music, dance, costume production, and performance. In this sense, they align with the functionalist position that cultural practices persist because they fulfill specific societal needs.

Durkheim's perspective further enhances the understanding that, in the face of modernity, globalization, and religious influences, cultural practices undergo transformation rather than disappearance. This process of adaptation is evident in the Ogbia social masquerades, which, despite the loss of overt ritualistic and metaphysical elements, continue to sustain social integration and cultural continuity. Their performative nature enables them to function as sites of collective participation, where communal identity is enacted and reinforced.

Moreover, beyond their functional role in cohesion, these masquerades can be understood as forms of social performance that mediate identity, memory, and cultural meaning. Through performance narratives, symbolic representation, and embodied practices, they transmit historical knowledge and value systems, thereby sustaining the cultural viability of the Ogbia people. This interpretive dimension extends the functionalist framework by situating masquerade within broader discussions of performance as social practice and cultural adaptation.

Through the application of Functionalist Theory, therefore, this research demonstrates that Ogbia social masquerades represent more than mere entertainment; they are adaptive cultural institutions that negotiate continuity and change while maintaining their relevance within contemporary society.

Research Methodology

The historical, sociological, and emic approaches are employed in this study. The researcher used the historical method in tracing the origin and development of the Ogbia people and their masquerade culture. This was achieved through the investigation of historical documents, artifacts, and oral interviews on the history and development of the communities where the masquerades under study are domiciled. These sources were carefully examined and cross-referenced to ensure consistency and reliability in the reconstruction of historical narratives.

For the sociological method, the researcher interacted with sampled members of the society under study. The custodians of the various masquerades under study were purposively selected and interviewed to ascertain the origin, development, and contemporary functions of their masquerades. This selection was based on their roles, knowledge, and direct involvement in the performance and management of the masquerades. The data generated from these interactions were critically examined and compared with existing scholarly literature to enhance validity and reduce subjectivity.

The emic model was achieved through the researcher's observation and camera recording as an insider in most of the masquerade performances, such as Oki of Otuobhi and Akpembe of Ewoi. This insider position provided direct experiential knowledge and a nuanced understanding of the performances. The emic perspective was not only used for description but also informed the interpretation of the meanings, functions, and cultural significance of the masquerades within their socio-cultural context.

Furthermore, the combination of these methods allows for methodological triangulation, thereby strengthening the reliability and credibility of the findings. The integration of historical documentation, sociological interaction, and insider observation ensures that the study moves beyond mere description to a more grounded and interpretive analysis of Ogbia social masquerade culture.

Cultural Context and Historical Background of the Ogbia People

Traditionally, Ogbia Town is the headquarters of the Ogbia-speaking people. Administratively, Ogbia was a county council area under Brass Division in 1955. On September 23, 1991, however, Ogbia District became known as Ogbia Local Government Area, with Ogbia Town as its headquarters. In pursuit of rural administrative convenience, four rural development centres were created from Ogbia Local Government in 1999: Ogbia Town, Ogbia Central, Kolo Creek, and Anyama (Milton 3). Geographically, Ogbia Local Government covers an area of 693.2 km² and has a population of about 267,400, based on the 2022 projection from the 2006 census (Ibulu 11). The people of Ogbia are predominantly farmers, fishermen and women, traders, civil servants, and politicians. The predominant language is Ogbia, which, as cited in Milton, Professor K. Williams classifies within the Delta–Cross River branch of the Benue-Congo language group (7). This socio-geographical context provides the foundation for understanding the cultural practices, including masquerade performance, within Ogbia society.

The origin of the Ogbia-speaking people is explained through two major schools of thought: the Ogbeyan school and the Ogbia Aborigines school. The Ogbeyan school of thought posits Ogbeyan as the founder of the Ogbia Kingdom. A major proponent of this view is His Royal Majesty, Rev. G. I. Amangala (1890–1960), the first Obanobhan (King) of Ogbia Kingdom. In his *Short History of Ijaw*, Amangala explains that Ogbeyan migrated from Benin (present-day Edo State), travelling through creeks until settling near what is now known as the Brass River. According to this account, Ogbeyan and his group encountered aboriginal inhabitants in the forest, engaged in trade, and eventually entered into conflict, leading to the assimilation of the aborigines into the Ogbeyan group. This narrative reflects processes of migration, encounter, and cultural integration that are central to identity formation in many African societies.

Amangala further explains that Ogbeyan's descendants, particularly Olei and Okoro, became progenitors of several Ogbia communities. Olei's lineage is linked to communities such as Otuogidi, Emeyal, Otuasega, Ewoi, and others, while Okoroma's descendants are associated with both Ogbia and Nembe settlements. Corroborating this Benin origin narrative, Alagoa records similar traditions among the Okoroma people, who trace their ancestry to migration through Iselema (Warri) before settling and expanding into their present locations. These accounts demonstrate patterns of cultural diffusion, migration, and intergroup relations that have shaped the socio-cultural configuration of the Ogbia people.

In contrast, the Ogbia Aborigines school of thought maintains that the Ogbia Kingdom was originally inhabited by indigenous groups prior to the 14th-century migration from Benin. Proponents such as M. O. Okpara and Efeka argue that these aboriginal populations, organized in small settlements such as Ebela, Itokopiri, Ogidi, and Emeni, were not extinguished but rather integrated with incoming groups. According to Okpara, the present-day Ogbia society emerged from this interaction between aborigines and migrants, rather than from a single migratory origin (6). This perspective underscores the complexity of Ogbia identity as a product of cultural interaction and continuity rather than a singular historical trajectory. While the Ogbeyan narrative remains the more widely accepted, the coexistence of these perspectives reflects the multiplicity of historical memory within the society.

Despite these divergent origin narratives, the Ogbia people share a unifying belief in “Enai Ogbia” (the Star of Ogbia) as a supreme spiritual guardian. This shared belief system reinforces communal identity and cohesion, aligning with broader African cosmological frameworks in which spiritual forces underpin social organization. The notion of unity is further reflected in the formation of the Ogbia Brotherhood in 1940 and the conceptualization of Ogbia Town in 1972, illustrating how cultural belief translates into socio-political organization.

At present, Ogbia Kingdom consists of forty-eight (48) communities distributed across four sub-autonomous clans: Oloibiri, Emeyal, Anyama, and Abureni. These clans encompass numerous communities, each contributing to the cultural diversity and collective identity of the Ogbia people. The historical significance of Oloibiri, notably as the site of Nigeria's first crude oil discovery in 1956, further situates Ogbia within broader national historical narratives. This socio-political structure provides the context within which cultural practices, including masquerade performance, are organized and sustained.

Scholarly perspectives in art, religion, and culture affirm that belief in supernatural forces is a fundamental aspect of societal organization (Okome qtd. in Darah, Akama & Agberia 62). Among the Ogbia people, this is reflected in their belief in “Enai Ogbia” and in the presence of communal and individual deities. While there is no singular national deity, each community maintains its own spiritual system, often centred on shrines such as “Ade ema.” Traditionally, ritual activities, including masquerade performances and communal ceremonies, were initiated within these sacred spaces before being presented publicly. However, the influence of Christianity and modernity has led to significant transformations in these practices, illustrating processes of cultural adaptation and de-ritualization.

Analysis of Ogbia Social Masquerades

The general name for masquerade among the Ogbia is “Ipo”. Ipo is a connotation for a bizarre personality, an entity that generates fear. Conceptually, masquerades are perceived as spirits originating from the forest or river. However, the fear associated with Ipo is often linked not only to spiritual connotations but also to its performative authority, including the ability to enforce discipline during performances. Within this framework, two types of masquerades are identified: “Ipo olo” (play or social masquerade) and “Ipo de Eru” (deified masquerade). The Ipo olo corresponds to social masquerades, characterized by diminished ritual elements and a focus on entertainment and cultural expression. Examples include Oki, Akpembe, Odemimom, Oburumadu, Egugum, Asu, Ekpo, and Okarabh Odor, with the present study focusing on Oki, Akpembe, Odemimom, and Oburumadu.

Etymologically and historically, masquerade culture in Ogbia emerges through multiple processes. One source is the veneration of communal deities and ancestral forces, where entities such as “Eru” and “Ade ema” manifest symbolically through masquerade performance. These practices reflect the integration of spirituality, governance, and cultural expression, particularly in rituals led by priests or community leaders. Such performances function as mechanisms of social regulation, purification, and communal renewal, aligning with broader African performance epistemologies.

Another significant source of masquerade development in Ogbia is cultural diffusion. Interaction with neighbouring communities has led to the adoption and adaptation of masquerade forms. The Egugum masquerade of Ologoghe, for instance, is adapted from Opobo traditions, illustrating how performance forms are reinterpreted within new cultural contexts. Similarly, masquerades such as Oburumadu, Oki, and Akpembe have origins traceable to neighbouring ethnic groups, demonstrating processes of borrowing, modification, and localization. These adaptations highlight the dynamic and fluid nature of masquerade as a cultural practice.

The case of the Ekpo masquerade in Otuabula II further illustrates these dynamics. Introduced through inter-cultural contact, its performance has generated debates regarding its classification as either ritualistic or social. While some interpretations attribute its performance to supernatural forces, others emphasize skill and artistic technique. This ambiguity reflects broader tensions between ritual and performance, as well as the shifting boundaries between sacred and secular practices.

From an analytical perspective, the classification of Ekpo as a social masquerade is supported by its performative characteristics and the absence of sustained ritual obligations. The emphasis on performance secrecy, audience appeal, and artistic display suggests a transition from ritual efficacy to performative spectacle. Furthermore, the decline of ritual enforcement mechanisms aligns with the functionalist notion of cultural transformation, where practices evolve to meet contemporary social needs.

Overall, masquerade practices among the Ogbia people encompass both ritualistic and social dimensions, with many contemporary forms reflecting processes of adaptation, diffusion, and de-ritualization. The masquerades examined in this study Oki, Akpembe, Odemimom, and

Oburumadu represent significant examples of this transformation, illustrating how cultural practices are continually redefined within changing socio-cultural contexts.

Discussion

Relevance of the Ogbia Social Masquerades Culture

The Ogbia Social Masquerades Oki of Otuobhi, Akpembe of Ewoi, Odemimom of Otuoke, and Oburumadu of Emeyal 11 are very important cultural symbols practiced by the Ogbia ethnic group in Bayelsa State. As secular, de-ritualized events, these masquerades, staged during the yuletide season, symbolize Ogbia cultural identity. Beyond their descriptive presentation as festive performances, they function as adaptive cultural systems that negotiate continuity and change through embodied performance, collective memory, and social participation. In the face of globalization characterized by homogenization, technological connectivity, and economic interdependency these masquerades sustain cultural relevance by reinforcing identity, social cohesion, artistic education, and cultural resilience. In this regard, the study demonstrates that Ogbia social masquerades are not merely performative spectacles but dynamic cultural mechanisms through which communal values are reproduced, contested, and reinterpreted in everyday social life.

Preservation of Ogbia Cultural Identity

Globalization poses a threat to indigenous culture through the diffusion of Western values and lifestyles expressed by the media. However, Ogbia social masquerades operate as embodied archives of cultural knowledge, where identity is performed rather than merely preserved. Each masquerade embodies symbolic narratives that reflect Ogbia cosmology and worldview, thereby functioning as what African performance epistemology describes as “living cultural texts.”

Oki of Otuobhi: Its environmental narrative of a fisherman chasing a predatory fish reflects an ecological consciousness embedded in Ogbia water-based heritage, as it educates viewers about coexisting with nature in a sustainable way.

Akpembe of Ewoi: The ritual of plantain cutting symbolized by cutting plantain trees in Otoko, Otama, and Ewoi's compounds symbolizes community unity. Beyond its descriptive form, it operates as a performative inscription of collective belonging across space.

Odemimom of Otuoke: As a harvest festival, it honors the agricultural ancestry of Ogbia, with forest-inspired costumes symbolizing their past connection to the Akpo forest, modified to suit festivity. This reflects cultural adaptation where memory is re-enacted within contemporary performance contexts.

Oburumadu of Emeyal 11: Through New Year parade performances and sponsor masquerades such as Api and Ofuruma, Oburumadu celebrates renewal and community pride, thereby maintaining Emeyal 11's rich cultural heritage. The movement across the six compounds further reinforces spatial unity and communal identity.

Collectively, these masquerades illustrate that cultural identity in Ogbia is not merely inherited but continuously produced through performance, embodiment, and collective

participation.

De-ritualization and Modernity

The movement from ritualistic to social forms, as pointed out by Dasylva's term "de-ritualisation," allows for access to all, including women and non-indigenes, across previously excluded barriers in conformity with global inclusive values. Rather than signifying cultural loss, this transformation reflects adaptive reconfiguration of meaning within contemporary socio-cultural realities. In this sense, de-ritualization should be understood not as the disappearance of sacred content, but as its relocation from exclusive ritual spaces into public cultural performance arenas where meaning is renegotiated through collective participation. This aligns with broader performance theory distinctions between ritual and theatre, where emphasis shifts from spiritual custodianship to embodied social expression.

For example, the spiritual taboos lost in Odemimom indicate some kinds of adaptation to Christian and modern influences, thus relating it to wide varieties of audiences. This transformation also reflects processes of cultural negotiation in which indigenous belief systems are reinterpreted rather than erased, allowing masquerade practice to remain socially relevant despite changing religious landscapes. In Ogbia context, such adaptation is evident in how performances in Otuoke and surrounding communities retain symbolic narratives while shedding restrictive ritual prescriptions. In theoretical terms, this aligns with performance studies' understanding of ritual-to-theatre transitions, where sacred exclusivity gives way to participatory cultural expression without total loss of symbolic structure.

Cultural Documentation

These masquerades, through annual performances involving the youths, pass down oral histories, songs, and dances that prevent cultural loss. The emic approach of the study, emphasizing insider perspectives, underlines their role of archiving Ogbia's heritage against globalization's homogenizing forces. This supports Mbiti's conceptualization of African cultural forms as "living traditions" (Mbiti 4), and Nzewi's view of performance as "total performance" (Nzewi 35), where music, dance, and drama function as integrated cultural systems. In practical terms, performances in Otuobhi, Ewoi, Otuoke, and Emeyal 11 operate as embodied archives where cultural memory is stored not in written texts but in repeated enactment, costume design, rhythmic structures, and narrative performance.

This is important in fostering community cohesion and social integration in a globalized world that has been characterized by fragmentation of communities when the youths migrate to urban centers or adopt external cultures. Social masquerades in Ogbia strengthen the social bond, reinforcing communal identity and resilience. They also serve as counter-narratives to cultural erosion by reaffirming belonging through shared aesthetic experience, especially during seasonal festivals where dispersed members of Ogbia communities return to participate.

Community Cohesion and Social Integration

While ritualistic masquerades were only available for women and initiates, such performances are now available to everyone and have brought about unity. The community tours in Akpembe's compound and processions in Emeyal 11's six compounds of Oburumadu involve the whole community, and spectators are "participant observers" as they join dances

and songs. While Oki is involved in communal dances and Odemimom is engaged in harvest celebrations, other groups such as visitors are brought together. This participatory expansion also reflects a shift in social structure where masquerade performance becomes a public civic event rather than an esoteric ritual institution, thereby enhancing inclusivity and reinforcing collective identity across age, gender, and social categories.

From a performance perspective, this participatory structure transforms masquerade spaces into shared social arenas where meaning is co-produced rather than passively received. In this way, masquerades function as performative sites of social negotiation in which identity, belonging, and communal memory are actively constructed through embodied interaction rather than symbolic observation alone.

Youth Engagement

These masquerades ensure that the youths remain anchored in Ogbia culture, as opposed to migrating to urban centers. For instance, Akpembe was reinstated by Ewoi youths as a means of promoting local celebrations in addition to Christmas, thus hindering movements to neighboring communities that might have encountered opposition. The promotion of Oki as a community activity in BOXING DAY also does so, demonstrating how indigenous cultural calendars are reactivated within modern festive systems. This demonstrates a strategic cultural adaptation where traditional performance systems are synchronized with globally recognized festive periods, thereby ensuring relevance within contemporary temporal and social realities.

Furthermore, youth participation in masquerades such as Oki, Akpembe, Odemimom, and Oburumadu in Otuobhi, Ewoi, Otuoque, and Emeyal 11 respectively functions as a form of cultural apprenticeship where identity, history, and performance skills are transmitted through practice rather than formal instruction.

Resistance to Cultural Extinction

By maintaining fixed performance dates and involving elders, youths, and visitors, the masquerades sustain community vitality, as seen in Oburumadu's role in New Year celebrations and burials, reinforcing social ties. This aligns with the project's objective to counter misconceptions of masquerades as demonic, often perpetuated by Christian influences, by showcasing their social utility. In this regard, masquerades function as cultural counter-institutions that challenge dominant religious and colonial narratives that historically marginalized indigenous performance traditions.

Rather than functioning as static traditions, these masquerades operate as adaptive cultural responses that reinterpret indigenous meaning within contemporary religious and social environments. Their continued relevance in Otuobhi, Ewoi, Otuoque, and Emeyal 11 demonstrates that cultural survival in Ogbia is not based on preservation alone but on continuous reinvention through performance, participation, and communal negotiation of meaning.

Overall, the contemporary significance of Ogbia social masquerades lies not only in their persistence but in their adaptive transformation across communities such as Otuobhi, Ewoi, Otuoque, and Emeyal 11. They embody processes of cultural diffusion, identity formation, embodiment, and social negotiation. By situating these performances within performance

theory, cultural studies, and African epistemologies, this study demonstrates that Ogbia social masquerades are not static cultural relics but living institutions through which society continuously interprets itself in the context of modernity and globalization.

Summary of Findings

The findings of the study indicates that, the Ogbia people have their origin from the Benin school of migration (the Ogbeyan school) as well as the Aborigines school, with cultural cohesion boosted by the creation of the Ogbia Brotherhood or the establishment of the town of Ogbia. Also, Ogbia masquerades have been categorized into ritualistic (Ipo de Eru) masquerades and social/play (Ipo Olo) masquerades, while some of the social masquerades have been categorized as Oki, Akpembe, Odemimom, and Oburumadu. Finally, the Ogbia social masquerades are significant in that they sustain the cultural identity of the people and are useful for youth engagement through arts education while also improving cultural visibility.

Recommendations

Based on the summarized findings, the study recommends that, to ensure the cultural knowledge and heritage of the Ogbia cultural group are maintained, all social masquerades, including Oki, Akpembe, Odemimom, and Oburumadu masquerades, should be documented in audio-visual form. Such measures will ensure the continuation of cultural skills in the creative arts. Also, locally based schools and community groups should integrate Ogbia social masquerades into their curricular and extracurricular programs. This will provide an activity through which young people are engaged in learning about traditional artistic and musical expression and other related skills and traditions of Ogbia ethnic identity. Finally, the government and other social bodies must advocate for Ogbia social masquerades as significant social attractions to be celebrated by all as part of their social heritage. Social platforms such as festivals and online platforms can be used to improve local and international recognition as well as create economic prospects for participants in these performances.

Conclusion

The research has proven that social masquerades of Ogbia descent Oki of Otuobhi, Akpembe of Ewoi, Odemimom of Otuoke, and Oburumadu of Emeyal 11 remain an important social phenomenon that sustains and passes down Ogbian social identity, values, and culture. The performances belong to social/play masquerades (Ipo Olo) and have developed from having potentially ritual aspects to modern, broad, and entertainment-oriented performances. The Ogbia social masquerades assume several contemporary roles: these include the preservation of cultural identity, promoting unity among social groups, offering younger generations opportunities for mastering traditional artistic skills of performing arts, and ensuring cultural visibility and economic engagement through festivals and tourism. The roles of these masquerades are generally secular and inclusive, contrary to ritualistic masquerades which have been generally limited to ritualistic contexts.

In the end, the research work brings to the fore the importance of the Ogbia social masquerades as living cultural resources that cannot be overshadowed or engulfed by cultural decline. Documenting, analyzing, and contextualizing the social masquerades, in this research work, is crucial in bringing to the fore their importance and creating an appropriate setting within the Global World.

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